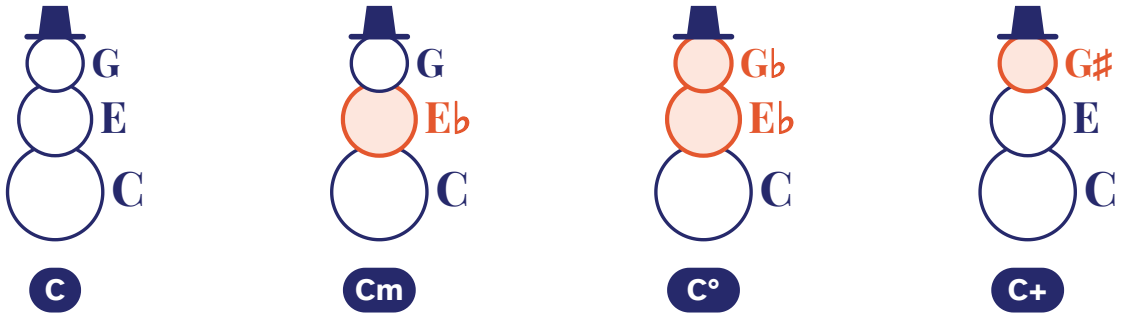
PART IV · HARMONY · 2

# Four kinds of triad

Every triad is two 3rds stacked. To tell the kinds apart, count the keys **in between**, black and white, that you do not play: root to 3rd, then 3rd to 5th. Those two numbers name the kind, and its sound.

**THE SECRET**

**Count the keys between: 3 + 2 is major, 2 + 3 is minor.**

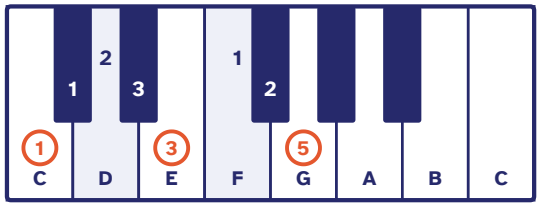



*Count the keys between: 3 + 2 is major, 2 + 3 is minor*

| KIND | KEYS BETWEEN | ON C | CHORD NAME | FIRST MET |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **major** | **3 + 2** | C E G | C | Level ½ |
| **minor** | **2 + 3** | C E♭ G | Cm | Level 2 |
| **diminished** | **2 + 2** | C E♭ G♭ | C° or Cdim | Level 5 |
| **augmented** | **3 + 3** | C E G♯ | C+ or Caug | Level 6 |

Chord names: a letter alone means major (C); m means minor (Cm). You see them above the melody in songbooks and lead sheets: C | Am | F | G. In interval names, 3 keys between is a major 3rd and 2 is a minor 3rd (p. {S2}).

## Count the keys in between




Play C and E and count the keys you skip, black and white: C♯, D, D♯ is **3**. Then E to G: F, F♯ is **2**. **3 + 2 is major.** Any root works the same way: from D, skip 3 to F♯, then 2 to A: D F♯ A, D major.

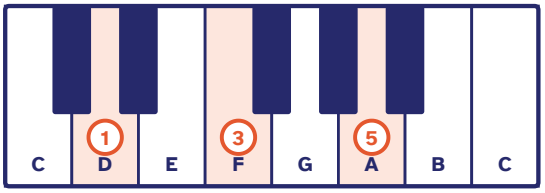
PART IV · HARMONY · 2 · CONTINUED

## How they sound

| KIND | SOUNDS | HEARD IN |
|---|---|---|
| major | bright, settled, open | most cheerful tunes, fanfares |
| minor | darker, softer, sadder | lullabies, laments, film tension |
| diminished | tense, unstable, wants to move | suspense, the chord before home |
| augmented | floating, dreamy, unsettled | dream scenes, a passing colour |

EXAMPLE

### Major or minor? D F A




1 **Root to 3rd:** D to F skips D♯ and E: **2**.
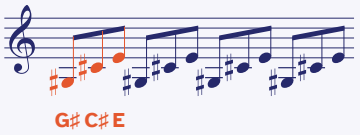
2 **3rd to 5th:** F to A skips F♯, G and G♯: **3**.

3 **2 + 3** is minor.

D F A is **D minor** (Dm). Three of the white-key triads are minor: D, E and A.

YOU KNOW THIS

### Beethoven, Moonlight Sonata (first movement)




The famous slow triplets are the notes of a **C♯ minor triad**: C♯, E and G♯, rocking gently. Minor is why it sounds so dark and sad.

THINK OF IT Two floors of a building: a tall floor (3 keys between) and a short one (2). Major: tall, then short, 3 + 2. Minor: short, then tall, 2 + 3. Diminished: two short, 2 + 2. Augmented: two tall, 3 + 3.

TRAP

- × Counting the keys you play: count only the keys in between, black and white.
- × Forgetting that in diminished and augmented triads the 5th changes too.
- × Spelling with the wrong letter: a triad skips one letter, so C minor is C E♭ G, never C D♯ G.

SEE ALSO
Chords and triads p. 67 · Major, minor and perfect p. 53

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 2 · Online: Library › Chords